

AKBai — Market Research & GTM Intelligence

Filipino MSME Pain Points · Community Sentiment · Targeting Playbook

Version 1.1

March 2026

12 Pain Points Documented

6 Community Sources Mapped

GTM Playbook v1

GTM Hooks Included

Overview

Communities

Pain Points

Keywords & Language

Executive Summary

Market validation from Filipino MSME communities — Reddit, Facebook groups, tax authority Q&As, and industry reports

12

Validated
Pain Points

6

Community
Sources
Mapped

₱0

Current
Taglish-first
tools

1.1M

Target MSME
Addressable

⚠ **Note on Reddit Access:** Reddit.com is blocked in this research environment for direct scraping. The pain points below are validated through: (1) secondary sources that aggregate Reddit/Facebook community questions (Taxumo blog, JuanTax blog, Rappler Tax Whiz

columns — which directly answer real user questions), (2) professional tax guides that document common MSME confusion patterns, and (3) authoritative Philippine business publications (Grant Thornton PH, PwC PH, CloudCFO). Community channels where these discussions actively happen are mapped below so the GTM team can monitor and engage them directly.

For live Reddit monitoring: Visit [r/buhaydigital](#), [r/phinvest](#), [r/FreelancePH](#), [r/Philippines](#) (search: "BIR", "accounting", "negosyo", "tax") and FB: "Buhay Digital Philippines" group, "Philippine Online Sellers Network", "Filipino Freelancers and VAs".

Community Landscape

Where Filipino MSMEs discuss their business problems — primary GTM seeding targets

REDDIT

r/buhaydigital

Filipino digital workers, freelancers, remote employees. Heavy BIR/tax discussion, tool recommendations, compliance questions. Very active.

~180K members (est.)

BIR registration

Freelancer tax

Accounting tools

Income tracking

REDDIT

r/phinvest

85K+ members. Filipino personal finance and investing. Side hustles, small business income, GCash savings, financial literacy discussions.

85,000+ members

Side hustle income

Online selling

Small biz finance

REDDIT

r/FreelancePH

Filipino freelancers on Upwork, Fiverr, local. Tax compliance, invoicing, international payment conversion, BIR registration.

~35K members (est.)

BIR COR

Invoice vs OR

GCash/Wise

ITR filing

REDDIT

FACEBOOK GROUP

FACEBOOK GROUP

r/Philippines

General Philippines community.
Occasional small business questions, "How do I start a negosyo?" posts, BIR confusion from new entrepreneurs.

400K+ members

Starting a business

BIR basics

DTI registration

Buhay Digital Philippines

Large FB community for digital workers. Similar content to r/buhaydigital but older demographic mix. Heavy on accounting confusion posts.

~500K+ members (est.)

Bookkeeping

Tax questions

Tools

Philippine Online Sellers Network / Negosyante PH

Home-based sellers, Shopee/Lazada/TikTok Shop resellers. Receipt chaos, platform fees confusion, GCash reconciliation, COD tracking.

~1M+ collective members

Shopee fees

GCash tracking

COD reconciliation

Pricinghelp

Pain Points

12 validated pain points from community research — each with GTM targeting angles

PP-01 · BIR Compliance

Critical

BIR Registration is Overwhelming — People Don't Know Where to Start

WHAT THEY SAY

- "The BIR registration process can be a confusing and daunting process, especially if you're not

THE NUMBERS

₱1K-50K penalty for non-registration
+25% surcharge on unpaid taxes

familiar with the requirements"

- Freelancers unsure whether to register as Professional, Single Proprietor, or Mixed Income Earner
- Multiple forms: 1901, 0605, 1906, 1905 — wrong one = wasted trips
- BIR offices: crowded, noisy, waiting from 7 AM to 5 PM

+20% interest

per year

2-3 RDO visits

average for

new registrants

PwC: Philippines ranked

among **most stressful countries for tax filing**

"Ang daming requirements, hindi ko alam kung saan magsisimula. Baka makukulong ako kung hindi ako mag-register."

— Representative sentiment from r/buhaydigital and Freelancer forums (paraphrased from aggregated community questions)

▣ **AKBAI SOLUTION**

Step-by-step BIR registration guide in Taglish, built into the onboarding flow. AI answers "Anong taxpayer type ako?" based on user's income type. Knowledge base covers Form 1901, 2303 (COR), books of accounts registration, and RD-specific requirements. Free tier: full BIR Q&A access.

▣ **GTM TARGETING**

- **Hook:** "BIR Registration in 5 Steps — Tanungin si AKBai, libre!"
- **Channels:** r/buhaydigital, r/FreelancePH, FB Buhay Digital PH group
- **Content:** Pinned comment on high-traffic BIR registration threads; short TikTok "BIR 101 in Taglish"
- **Organic play:** Answer every "How to register with BIR" post — high search intent

Official Receipt → Service Invoice Transition (BIR RR 7-2024) — Nobody Knows

WHAT THEY SAY

- BIR mandated transition from Official Receipts to Service Invoices effective April 26, 2024
- "This is frustrating, especially for freelancers that still have a lot of unused OR"
- Sellers complained about "doubled work" with new inventory submission requirements
- Businesses don't know the difference between OR, SI, CR, DR — penalized for wrong document

THE NUMBERS

P500 annual COR fee
(waived 2024+)

P1,000 cost for 10 new
Service Invoice booklets

Penalty for issuing wrong
document type

Many businesses unaware
rule even changed in 2024

"Many businesses are still penalized for non-issuance... many, its lack of awareness and knowledge of the business owner and/or his staff on how to write a receipt or invoice."

— BIR-cited finding on invoice non-compliance, aggregated from audit cases

AKBAI SOLUTION

AKBai explains the OR → Service Invoice transition in plain Taglish. Built-in invoice generator for Pro/Business tier. Knowledge base stays updated with BIR Revenue Regulations — this is a living asset competitors can't easily replicate.

GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "Huwag nang gamitin ang OR mo — napalitan na ng Service Invoice. Alam ni AKBai ang tamang paraan."

- **Urgency:** This is a recent (2024) change — massive awareness gap = high-intent traffic
- **Content:** Blog post "BIR RR 7-2024 Explained in Tagalog" — SEO goldmine

PP-03 · Tax Structure

Critical

Percentage Tax vs. 8% Income Tax vs. VAT — Critical Choice, Zero Guidance

WHAT THEY SAY

- PHP 3M threshold determines 3% Percentage Tax vs. 12% VAT — most sellers don't know this
- 8% flat income tax option available — but confusingly rarely explained
- "Mixing up gross sales and net taxable income is one of the most common mistakes"
- Crossing the ₱3M threshold triggers mandatory VAT — a growth disincentive

THE NUMBERS

₱3M threshold
(Percentage Tax → VAT)
3% Percentage Tax (if below ₱3M)
12% VAT (if above ₱3M)
8% flat income tax option (optional)
₱250K threshold for income tax exemption

"Freelancers can choose between Percentage Tax, VAT, or 8% flat income tax option, but guidance is unclear about which one applies."

— JuanTax/Taxumo community Q&A aggregation (high-frequency question type)

AKBAI SOLUTION

"Anong tax structure ang tama para sa'yo?" — AKBai asks 3 questions and recommends the correct tax regime. Year-end alert

when user approaches ₱3M gross (avoid VAT surprise). Tax calculator built into briefing. Free tier access.

□ GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "₱3M na ba ang kita mo ngayong taon? May malaking buwis na naghihintay sa'yo. Alamin sa AKBai."
- **Tool:** Free tax regime calculator on landing page — drives sign-ups
- **SEO:** "8% tax Philippines freelancer" — extremely high search volume, low competition

PP-04 · Tool Frustration

□ Critical

Existing Tools Are Too Expensive, Too English, or Too Limited for Filipino MSMEs

WHAT THEY SAY ABOUT EACH TOOL

- **QuickBooks:** \$17.5–117.5/month — "too expensive, designed for US businesses"
- **Wave:** Free but "not suitable for BIR-registered businesses" — no DAT files, no BIR forms
- **Taxumo:** ₱399/month — tax only, not integrated accounting; "limited for complex scenarios"
- **JuanTax:** BIR-certified but *only works with Xero* — can't use standalone
- **Xero:** \$20–80/month — too costly for sub-₱3M sellers

THE GAP

₱3K–15K/mo outsourced bookkeeper cost
100% of top tools: English-only UI
0 tools with Taglish AI Q&A
0 tools designed for GCash + Shopee workflows
~₱399–499/mo AKBai Pro — 10× cheaper than bookkeeper

"If you pick a system that doesn't connect with your workflows (sales, inventory, bank feeds) or your compliance needs (BIR forms, CAS registration, DAT files), you may end up doing lots of manual work."

— HashMicro Philippines Accounting Software Guide (aggregating Filipino MSME feedback)

▣ **AKBAI SOLUTION**

AKBai is the only mobile-first, Taglish-native business partner designed specifically for GCash + Shopee/Lazada/TikTok Shop workflows. Pro at ₱399/month (Y1) vs. ₱3K–15K/month outsourced. BIR knowledge built-in. No accounting degree required.

▣ **GTM TARGETING**

- **Hook:** "Hindi mo kailangan ng accountant na ₱5,000/buwan. Si AKBai, ₱399 lang."
- **Comparison content:** "AKBai vs. Taxumo vs. QuickBooks — Para sa Filipino Seller"
- **Trigger moment:** Target people posting "What accounting app do you use?" in r/buhaydigital

PP-05 · Language Barrier

▣ **Critical**

"Wala Akong Alam Sa Accounting" — Foundational Business Literacy Gap

WHAT THEY SAY

- Most sari-sari store owners do zero accounting despite legal requirements
- "Tax filing has been considered one of the worst painful tasks most Filipinos struggle with"
- New business owners don't know the difference

THE NUMBERS

9.9M MSME businesses in Philippines
~60% informal/unregistered (estimated)
0 Taglish-first accounting AI exists
Employers auto-withhold; freelancers must figure it out alone

between revenue, gross profit, and net income

- All top accounting tools have English-only interfaces — literacy barrier for many sellers

"Unlike employed individuals (where tax is automatically withheld), freelancers have to navigate the complicated system of filing income taxes entirely on their own."

— Taxumo blog (directly addressing the most common user question pattern)

▣ **AKBAI SOLUTION**

AKBai explains profit, cash flow, gross margin, and BIR terms in Taglish — conversationally, not in jargon. "Kumusta ang negosyo mo today?" daily check-in teaches financial literacy while collecting data. Meets users where they are linguistically.

▣ **GTM TARGETING**

- **Hook:** "Hindi ka accountant? Ok lang. Si AKBai, Tagalog ang pag-usapan natin."
- **Content series:** "Business basics sa Tagalog" — TikTok/Reels series targeting zero-experience sellers
- **Positioning:** AKBai is a teacher AND a tool — not just software

PP-06 · Multi-Channel Chaos

▣ **High**

Multi-Platform Reconciliation — Shopee + Lazada + TikTok Shop + GCash + COD

WHAT THEY SAY

- "Only recording gross sales without subtracting platform or ad fees" — invisible profit drain

THE NUMBERS

7+ days platform payout delay (typical)

1-9% Shopee commission

- COD orders: cash collected by courier, remitted days later — no reconciliation trail
- Shopee/Lazada commissions (1–9%/11%) often not factored into pricing
- Sellers celebrate high sales then can't pay suppliers — cash timing mismatch

11% Lazada commission
1% tax withheld by platforms >₱500K gross (RR 16-2023)
 GCash: only 15 transactions visible in app history

"Without monthly reconciliation, sellers cannot make informed decisions about restocking inventory or adjusting ad spend. Platform fees, gateway charges, shipping costs, returns, and promotional expenses accumulate untracked."

— AccountaholicsPH, Filipino e-commerce bookkeeping guide (practitioner-derived insights)

▢ **AKBAI SOLUTION**

Excel/CSV upload (Pro) accepts Shopee/Lazada payout reports. Business tier: GSheets live sync for real-time reconciliation. Daily check-in captures cash sales and GCash payments. Weekly reconciliation prompts surface missing data. Monthly summary shows true net income per channel.

▢ **GTM TARGETING**

- **Hook:** "Malaki na sales mo sa Shopee pero wala pa ring pera? Naroon ang sagot sa AKBai."
- **Target community:** Philippine Online Sellers FB group — extremely high pain density here
- **Feature demo:** Show Shopee CSV upload → instant P&L summary (video content)

Keeping Financial Records Updated is Too Hard — Sellers Fall Behind and Stop Trying

WHAT THEY SAY

- Tracking income in a notebook — then lose the notebook
- GCash only shows last 15 transactions without requesting history (takes days)
- Start tracking in Excel, stop after week 2 when business gets busy
- End-of-month bookkeeping becomes a 2–3 day marathon of receipt hunting

THE NUMBERS

P3K-15K/mo bookkeeper alternative
2-3 days manual month-end close time
GCash only 15 visible transactions in-app
 Key insight: **habit-forming data entry** is the product's daily value driver

"Having a dedicated business account is crucial for managing expenses, tracking income, and preparing for tax obligations — but many operate entirely through cash or GCash without formal systems."

— Philippine Business Tools, home-based seller guide (reflects widespread practitioner observation)

AKBAI SOLUTION

Daily Check-In (in-app, configurable time, default 8PM):

"Kumusta ang negosyo mo today? Magkano ang sales? Magkano ang gastos?" — 60-second habit. **Weekly Reconciliation**

(Friday): batch-fill missing days. **Excel/CSV upload + GSheets**

sync for Pro/Business. **Notebook photo OCR** (Pro): take photo of handwritten ledger, AKBai extracts the numbers.

GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "60 segundo lang bawat araw para malaman kung kumikita ka ba. AKBai check-in — libre."

- **Differentiator to emphasize:** This is the only tool that meets sellers where they are — notebook photos, Excel, or just text
- **Virality:** Monthly summary card shareable on IG/FB — "₱48,520 kita ko this month!" organic spread

PP-08 · Hidden Cost Leakage

High

Platform Fees, Returns, and Ad Spend Eat Margins Invisibly

WHAT THEY SAY

- Sellers price based on product cost only — platform fee, shipping, packaging not included
- Shopee Coins cashback and vouchers reduce seller remittance — confusing accounting treatment
- Return rate not factored — real margin vs. perceived margin gap widens over time
- "Many operate at 10-15% margin when they should be targeting 25-50%"

THE NUMBERS

10-15% typical actual margin (vs. 25-50% target)

1-9% Shopee platform fee alone

+shipping ₱50-150/order absorbed by seller

Deductible items missed = taxes overpaid

AKBAI SOLUTION

AKBai's pricing assistant calculates true landed cost including platform fees, shipping, packaging, and return rate. Monthly briefing surfaces "You're spending ₱4,200/month on platform fees — here's how it affects your margin." Pro tier: upload Shopee payout CSV for exact reconciliation.

□ GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "₱1,000 ang presyo mo sa Shopee. Alam mo bang ₱720 lang ang talagang nakukuha mo? Si AKBai, ipapaliwanag."
- **Content angle:** "Ang totoo mong kita sa Shopee" — viral-worthy calculation reveals

PP-09 · Withholding Tax Surprise

□ High

Platform Withholding Tax (RR 16-2023) — Sellers Didn't Know Until Payout Was Lower

WHAT THEY SAY

- Shopee/Lazada now withholds 1% (on 50% of gross) for sellers earning >₱500K/year
- Many sellers noticed smaller payout and didn't know why — no in-app explanation
- Creates confusion about whether this satisfies income tax obligation (it doesn't — it's just a creditable withholding)
- Content creators: TikTok Fund, YouTube AdSense, Shopee affiliate — which is taxable?

THE NUMBERS

₱500K annual gross threshold
1% × 50% = 0.5% effective withholding rate
Creditable — applies to income tax, not replacement
Affects: Shopee, Lazada, TikTok Shop, Grab, Foodpanda sellers

□ AKBAI SOLUTION

AKBai proactively alerts users approaching ₱500K gross: "Mag-iingat ka na — mag-a-apply na ang withholding tax sa susunod na buwan." Explains in Taglish what the deduction is, that it's creditable, and how to factor it into ITR. Year-end withholding reconciliation prompt.

□ GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "Bakit mas mababa ang payout mo sa Shopee ngayong buwan? Baka nasa ₱500K ka na. Alamin sa AKBai."
- **Timing:** Target November-January (when year-end sellers hit thresholds)

PP-10 · Cash Flow Blindness

□ High

Good Sales, No Cash — The Filipino Seller's Most Painful Paradox

WHAT THEY SAY

- "Sellers celebrate large sales but can't pay rent due to platform payouts delayed 7+ days"
- Restock purchase timing vs. payout timing mismatch — cash crunch despite healthy P&L
- No real-time visibility into liquidity — making decisions on feelings not numbers
- Informal business loans (5-6 lending) taken due to cash timing gaps

THE NUMBERS

7+ days Shopee payout cycle
COD risk courier remittance delays add 3-5 more days
5-6 lending 20-25% monthly informal interest rate (desperate alternative)

□ AKBAI SOLUTION

AKBai daily briefing includes "Expected cash inflows this week" from pending platform payouts + GCash balance trends. Cash flow projection for next 30 days based on current sales trajectory. Restock timing advice: "Mag-order ka ng stock pagdating ng Friday — 'yan ang expected payout mo."

□ GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "Malaki ang benta, bakit wala pang cash? AKBai ipinapaliwanag kung kailan darating ang pera mo."
- **Empathy-led content:** "Pangako ng Shopee" — storytelling content resonating with sellers who've been through this

PP-11 · Tax Structure Decisions

□ High

DAT Files, CAS Registration, BIR Form Complexity — For Growing Businesses

WHAT THEY SAY

- Computerized Accounting System (CAS) registration required when using software — few know this
- DAT (Digital Accounting Tax) files must conform to BIR XML schemas — technical nightmare
- Monthly deadlines: 2550M, 2550Q, 1601-E, 2316, 2307 — error-prone manual filling
- Affordable tools can't generate BIR-compliant DAT files — forces expensive accountant hire

THE NUMBERS

6+ forms monthly/
quarterly BIR deadlines
P3K-15K accountant cost
to handle these
0 affordable tools that
auto-generate BIR forms for
MSMEs
Phase 2+ AKBai roadmap
item

□ AKBAI SOLUTION (ROADMAP)

Phase 3 roadmap: BIR form pre-fill assistance for 1701Q, 2551Q, and monthly returns. Business tier: deadline calendar with proactive reminders per BIR filing schedule. Long-term: DAT file preparation assistance (differentiating from Taxumo which is tax-only).

□ GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "Alam mo ba kung anong BIR forms ang dapat mo i-file ngayong buwan? Si AKBai, may calendar para sa'yo."
- **Target:** Growing businesses graduating past Taxumo's capabilities

PP-12 · Freelancer/Creator Blind Spot

□ High

Content Creators & Digital Nomads — Tax Obligations Completely Unknown

WHAT THEY SAY

- BIR actively reminding YouTubers and social media influencers to register — many unaware
- TikTok Creator Fund, YouTube AdSense, Shopee affiliate — which is taxable? (All of it)
- Digital nomad visa (June 2025) created new confusion about local income tax obligations
- International payment via Wise, PayPal, Payoneer — exchange rate tracking missing

THE NUMBERS

Growing fast content creator economy in PH
All income from all platforms = taxable in Philippines
New visa Digital Nomad Visa (June 2025) = new audience segment
0 tools explain this in Tagalog

□ AKBAI SOLUTION

AKBai handles mixed income: employment + online selling + creator income. Explains taxability of each platform in Taglish. Quarterly estimated tax calculator for variable income. Multi-currency awareness for Wise/PayPal income (Phase 2 roadmap).

□ GTM TARGETING

- **Hook:** "Kumikita ka sa TikTok at YouTube? Alam mo bang may buwis 'yan? Si AKBai, tutulungan ka."
- **Channel:** TikTok/Instagram — reach creators in their native platform
- **Timing:** January (ITR season) and April (Q1 deadline) push

Keywords & Filipino Language Patterns

The exact language Filipinos use when searching for help — use these in content, SEO, and ad copy

□ High-Intent Search Terms

BIR & TAX REGISTRATION

BIR registration freelancer Philippines

how to register BIR self-employed

8% flat tax Philippines freelancer

BIR Form 1901 guide

Certificate of Registration BIR

paano mag register sa BIR

BIR registration para sa online seller

anong tax ang para sa maliit na negosyo

ACCOUNTING & BOOKKEEPING

accounting app Philippines small business

bookkeeping online seller Philippines

how to track income Philippines freelancer

Taxumo vs alternative Philippines

paano mag track ng sales at expenses

accounting para sa negosyante

hindi ko alam mag account ng negosyo

ONLINE SELLING SPECIFIC

Shopee seller accounting Philippines

withholding tax online seller Philippines 2024

1% withholding tax Shopee explained

GCash income tracking Philippines

bakit mas mababa ang payout ko sa Shopee

paano malaman ang totoo kong kita sa online selling

GCash reconciliation negosyo

EMOTIONAL / FEAR-BASED TRIGGERS

makukulong ba ako kung hindi mag file ng tax

nakalimutan ko mag file ng tax

BIR penalty paano bayaran

mukhang magbabayad ako ng malaking buwis

BIR penalty Philippines how to avoid

late BIR filing Philippines what to do

GTM Hook Playbook by Channel

Ready-to-use messaging hooks mapped to channels and pain points — prioritized for organic (P0 cost) first

PAIN POINT	HOOK (TAGLISH)	CHANNEL(S)	TRIGGER MOMENT
PP-01 BIR Registration Confusion	<i>"BIR Registration sa 5 Steps — Tanungin si AKBai, libre!"</i>	r/buhaydigital r/FreelancePH TikTok	When user posts "how to register BIR" or "paano mag-register"
PP-02 OR →	<i>"Huwag nang gamitin ang OR</i>		High search volume, low

PAIN POINT	HOOK (TAGLISH)	CHANNEL(S)	TRIGGER MOMENT
Service Invoice	<i>mo — napalitan na ng Service Invoice noong 2024."</i>	SEO blog FB groups	content competition — SEO priority
PP-03 Tax Structure Confusion	<i>"P3M na ba ang kita mo ngayong taon? May malaking buwis na naghihintay."</i>	Landing page calculator r/phinvest	Year-end (Oct-Dec) when sellers project annual totals
PP-04 Tool Frustration	<i>"Hindi mo kailangan ng accountant na P5,000/buwan. Si AKBai, P399 lang."</i>	r/buhaydigital Facebook ads Comparison posts	When users post "what accounting app do you use?"
PP-05 Accounting Literacy	<i>"Hindi ka accountant? Ok lang. Taglish ang pag-usapan natin ni AKBai."</i>	TikTok Instagram Reels YouTube Shorts	Always-on content — evergreen for new business starters
PP-06 Multi-Channel Chaos	<i>"Malaki ang sales sa Shopee pero wala pang pera? Naroon ang sagot sa AKBai."</i>	PH Online Sellers FB TikTok demo video	After platform payout disappointment posts in seller groups
PP-07 Data Entry Friction	<i>"60 segundo lang bawat araw. 'Kumusta ang negosyo mo?' — AKBai daily check-in."</i>	App Store listing Onboarding email Referral	Activation messaging — first 7 days post-signup
PP-09 Withholding Tax Surprise	<i>"Bakit mas mababa ang payout mo sa</i>		November-January when

PAIN POINT	HOOK (TAGLISH)	CHANNEL(S)	TRIGGER MOMENT
	<i>Shopee? Baka nasa ₱500K ka na."</i>	FB Online Sellers Shopee seller forums	sellers approach annual threshold
PP-10 Cash Flow Blindness	<i>"Malaki ang benta, bakit wala pang cash? Ipinapaliwanag ni AKBai kung kailan darating."</i>	r/phinvest Negosyante FB groups	After payday when sellers check balances vs. expected
PP-12 Content Creator Blindspot	<i>"Kumikita ka sa TikTok at YouTube? Alam mo bang may buwis 'yan?"</i>	TikTok Creator communities	ITR season (January–April) and BIR crackdown news events

Community-Revealed Competitive Gaps

Specific whitespace no competitor is filling — directly from community frustrations



Taglish / Filipino Language Interface **ZERO**

COMPETITION

Every tool from QuickBooks to Wave to Taxumo is English-only. Filipino communities repeatedly ask for explanations in "simple terms" — this is a language problem masquerading as an education problem. AKBai's Taglish-first design is a genuine, defensible competitive moat that no tool can retrofit easily.



GCash + COD + Shopee Workflow Integration

ZERO COMPETITION

No accounting tool is designed around how Filipino sellers actually transact: GCash for small purchases, COD for marketplace orders, direct bank transfer for wholesale, and occasional credit card. QuickBooks and Xero assume bank feeds. AKBai assumes GCash screenshots and Excel payout exports.



Notebook Photo OCR (Multi-Modal Data Entry)

ZERO COMPETITION

Community research reveals many sellers keep physical notebooks or simple spreadsheets — not because they prefer it, but because no digital tool fits their workflow. AKBai's notebook photo OCR meets them exactly where they are. No competitor offers this.



Daily Habit-Forming Check-In

ZERO COMPETITION

All accounting tools are reactive — the seller opens the app when they want to review. AKBai is proactive — it asks the seller daily. This daily touch creates retention, data completeness, and literacy simultaneously. No competitor has this feature for the MSME market.



Proactive BIR Threshold Alerts (₱250K, ₱500K, ₱3M)

ZERO COMPETITION

The community repeatedly shows sellers are surprised by BIR obligations they didn't know about — especially the ₱500K withholding threshold and ₱3M VAT threshold. AKBai is the first tool designed to alert sellers *before* they cross these thresholds. No competitor does this proactively in Taglish.



Real-Time BIR Regulation Updates in Conversational AI

STRONG MOAT

BIR RR 7-2024 (OR → Service Invoice) caught thousands of sellers off guard. Taxumo published a blog post. AKBai can notify users in-app, in Taglish, with step-by-step action items. The living knowledge base — kept current with every BIR issuance — is a compounding defensible asset that grows harder to replicate over time.

First 100 Users GTM Playbook

Evidence-based acquisition strategies for AKBai's launch phase — mapped to the Filipino MSME context. Based on research from Lenny's Newsletter, YC founder playbooks, and Mercury's first-customer frameworks.

□ The Core Principle: Do Things That Don't Scale

Every consumer app that found its first 100 users did it through methods that cannot be copy-pasted at scale. The goal is not efficiency — it is signal. Each early user is a research subject, a testimonial, and a distribution node within their network. Anton is the primary GTM engine until ₱500K ARR.

- **Founder-led GTM rule:** No paid acquisition until at least 100 organic users are paying. Every peso spent on ads before product-market fit is wasted learning budget.
- **Primary channel:** Facebook MSME communities (Negosyante PH, Online Sellers PH) — 1M+ combined members, zero ad spend required, pain points visible in plain text every day.
- **Target first user profile:** Sari-sari/food seller, 25-40, active in at least one FB MSME group, currently tracking sales in notebook or GCash history, has had at least one BIR-related anxiety moment in the past 12 months.

1-10

10-30

30-70

70-
100

Users

Personal network — friends, family, suki with a tindahan. Collect qualitative feedback. No payment required yet.

Users

FB community infiltration — genuine posts answering real questions, soft mention of AKBai. Manual onboarding of each user.

Users

FB group admin partnership — offer free Business tier to 3-5 group admins. Each admin endorsement reaches 10K-100K members.

Users

Waitlist FOMO — queue counter visible, referral queue-jump active. First conversion push for paid Pro tier.

7 First-User Acquisition Strategies — Ranked for AKBai

Facebook

1

Community Infiltration

PRIMARY

Join Negosyante PH, Online Sellers PH, Freelancers PH, and similar FB groups. Spend 2-4 weeks providing genuine value — answer BIR questions, share tax guides, help with filing confusion. Build credibility first, then mention AKBai naturally as your own tool.

AKBai play: "Ginagamit ko yong AKBai para dito — may AI siya na sumasagot ng BIR questions sa Taglish. Beta pa lang siya ngayon, pag gusto mong subukan." Attach a screenshot of the tool answering a real question from that thread.

Offline

2

Personal Outreach

PRIMARY

Face-to-face or Messenger DM with personal connections who are actual MSME operators. These users give the most honest feedback and are the most forgiving of early bugs. Target sari-sari store owners, food sellers, online resellers in your direct personal network.

AKBai play: Show the app live. Walk them through scanning a receipt or asking a BIR question. Let them feel the wow moment before you ask them to sign up. Offer to set up their account together in 10 minutes — co-onboarding creates deep loyalty.

FB Group

3 Admin Influencer Play **HIGH LEVERAGE**

Identify 3-5 admins of major MSME FB groups who are themselves MSME operators. Reach out personally, offer a permanent free Business tier account in exchange for honest feedback and, if they find it useful, a genuine recommendation to their group.

AKBai play: No formal agreement needed. This is genuine product placement, not advertising. If the admin does not like the product after using it for 2 weeks, no obligation. One admin post in a 50K-member group = 100+ waitlist signups from a single organic endorsement.

Waitlist

+ 4 Queue Counter FOMO **HIGH LEVERAGE**

Launch a pre-access waitlist before full launch. Display a live queue count on the landing page ("1,247 negosyante ang naghihintay"). Users can jump the queue by referring others — creating social proof, urgency, and viral referral loops at zero cost.

AKBai play: Open during Phase 0B pilot. Counter starts at real number and updates live. Message: "Sinalihan ka namin sa waitlist — ikaw ay #847. Mag-refer ng kaibigan para mapabilis ang iyong access." The queue mechanic is itself a distribution engine.

Pre-Launch

5 Content Community **SUPPORT**

Start posting educational BIR/tax content on a dedicated Facebook page or TikTok account 60-90 days before launch. Each post builds an audience that already trusts AKBai as a knowledge

Reddit +

6 Press Outreach **SUPPORT**

Post a genuine builder thread in r/buhaydigital and r/phinvest — not advertising, but a founder sharing what they are working on. Filipino Reddit communities are receptive to authentic local startup stories. Also pitch to

source before the product is publicly available.

AKBai play: Weekly formats: "BIR Alert of the Week," "Tanong sa AKBai" Q&A videos, "Magkano ang Buwis Mo?" explainer threads. Taglish only. Link to waitlist in bio. Content is both top-of-funnel acquisition and long-term SEO asset.

Rappler, CNN Philippines, or BusinessWorld digital.

AKBai play: Post title: "I built an AI that answers BIR questions in Taglish for small sellers — looking for beta testers." Real story, no marketing language. Attach a demo GIF of the chat answering "Magkano ang tax ko sa 500K na kita?" — a question that resonates with the entire target community.

Direct

7

Power User

SUPPORT

Invitations

Identify the most helpful people in MSME communities — those already answering BIR questions and posting tax guides. These are natural AKBai evangelists. Reach out directly and offer early access. They become product champions before you ever ask them to promote it.

AKBai play: Search target FB groups for posts with 50+ comments. Note the same 3-5 knowledgeable responders. DM them: "Napansin ko madalas kang sumasagot ng tax questions dito. Gusto mo subukan ang tool na gumagawa ng ganyan sa Taglish?" These people already

have trust capital in the community.

PRIORITY	CHANNEL	EFFORT	COST	EXPECTED USERS (0-100 PHASE)	NOTES
#1	FB MSME Community Posts	High (daily)	₱0	30-50	Primary channel. Requires genuine value-add posts. Build trust for 2- weeks before mentioning AKBai.
#1	Personal Network Outreach	Medium	₱0	10-20	Highest conversion rate. Every person onboarded personally becomes a advocate. Do this before any public launch.
#2	FB Group Admin Partnership	Low (3-5 DMs)	₱0 (free tier)	20-50 per admin	Highest leverage play. One admin with 50K members : potentially

					100+ signups from one post. Highest ROI of any channel.
#3	Waitlist + Referral Loop	Low (setup)	₱0	50-200 signups	Works as amplifier alongside other channels. A waitlist without traffic driving to it achieves nothing on its own.
#4	Pre-Launch Content (FB/TikTok)	Medium (weekly)	₱0	Builds launch audience	Start 60+ days before launch. SE benefit compounds over time. Taglish content is the long-term organic moat.
#5	Reddit + Press	Low (one-time)	₱0	5-15 + credibility	Lower user yield but builds credibility. buhaydigit post frame as genuine founder story can drive

50-100
profile
views.

⚠ **Founder Mandate: Things That Don't Scale — Do These Until ₱500K ARR**

- **Manually onboard every early user** — Call, Messenger, or meet in person. Set up their account together. Answer every question personally. This creates advocates, not just users.
- **Read every BIR-related Facebook post** in your target communities for 1 hour every morning. Respond genuinely. Your name becomes synonymous with reliable BIR help before the product even launches.
- **DM every person who comments on your community posts** — even those who do not ask for the product. Build the relationship first, then offer AKBai when it is relevant to their situation.
- **Call every churned user within 24 hours** — especially in the first 3 months. The reason someone leaves is worth more than 10 positive testimonials for improving the product.
- **Send a personal follow-up message** after every user's first BIR deadline handled by AKBai: "Kumusta ang filing mo? Nakapag-file ka na ba?" This one touchpoint has outsized retention impact and demonstrates that AKBai is a partner, not a tool.
- **Do NOT hire sales until 200+ paying users.** Every conversation should be founder-led. You learn faster, iterate faster, and the product improves faster when the builder is also the seller.
- **Do NOT run paid ads** until the organic conversion path is validated. Paid ads amplify what is already working — they cannot substitute for product-market fit.

📊 **Key GTM Metrics — Track These From Day 1**

METRIC	TARGET (MONTH 1-3)	WHY IT MATTERS
Waitlist signups	500+	

		Demand validation before launch; creates Day 1 user pool without ads
Waitlist → active user conversion	30%+	Indicates messaging-to-product fit; below 20% means revisit onboarding
Free → Pro conversion	10-15%	Primary revenue signal; below 8% means revisit paywall placement or value prop
Day 7 retention	40%+	Habit formation indicator; below 30% means daily briefing is not sticky enough
Flag-as-Wrong rate (AI accuracy)	<10% (target <5%)	Trust signal; above 15% risks word-of-mouth turning negative in communities
Referral rate	15%+	Organic growth multiplier; above 20% means the product is self-distributing